

pulled off the “biggest military computer hack of all time” fought them off successfully. He still resides in the UK, having started his own SEO business.

In a BBC interview in 2005, McKinnon said that when he realised that US military used Windows, he just assumed it would be easy to hack into them if they weren’t secured properly. He encountered many US military machines without adequate password or firewall protection, and left that famous message – Your security is crap – on several machines he penetrated. Way to drive home a point, eh?

LAUGHING AT YOUR SECURITY SINCE 2011

I think we can all agree that hacker group LulzSec were a lot of fun until they lasted. An Internet sensation with six founding members, LulzSec burst onto the scene by hacking into popular targets and defacing their properties – all for the sake of a few online laughs, it seemed. From hacking Fox News’ website, internal emails, leaking passwords and sensitive company information, to hacking accounts



Keep calm and hack on, good sir

of Sony Pictures and bringing down the CIA’s website, LulzSec’s every act was a global headline. They even posted a fake story of media baron Rupert Murdoch’s death in News Corp’s several publications that he himself owned – if that doesn’t demonstrate the group’s sense of irony, we don’t know what does.

Their self-proclaimed ideology claimed to just hack for fun by causing mayhem, and not being motivated by hacking for financial profit. Many online and security commentators have given

LulzSec credit for one thing, though. By defacing online properties of reputed organisations and companies, they definitely helped ramp up the security preparedness of every online entity that heard of them – and that is a greater testimony to their legacy than all the laughs and giggles they had at their victims’ expense. While LulzSec’s founding members have officially “retired” and the group has ceased its activities, their motto – “laughing at your security since 2011” – continues to inspire other splinter groups to follow in their infamous footsteps.

AM I THE 102ND CALLER?

Kevin Poulsen began his life on the dark side. A smart, intelligent fella with rare technical acumen, Poulsen was prone to mischief, meddling in the world of hacking from a young age. In fact, he was a very good black hatter back in the day, pulling off one of the most insane LOL moments in America.

Around the same time Happy Birthday Joshi virus started replicating across systems in India (and around the world), 25-year-old Kevin Poulsen was trying to get himself a brand new Porsche – for FREE! How? By taking over all the phone lines of Los Angeles-based radio station, KIIS-FM’s, virtually guaranteeing no one else could call in during the live raffle (the car was supposed to be awarded to the 102nd caller on the day), thereby ensuring he won himself the Porsche 944 S2 – selling for up to US \$50,000 at the time.

Obviously, the radio station smelt a rat and called the Feds. Poulsen went underground sensing the FBI on his tail but couldn’t evade arrest for long. He was caught, sentenced to five years in prison, and an additional three years of ban from using computers or the internet – thus becoming the first person



Well, not anymore

to serve an internet ban in America – an infamous feat.

But after his release, Poulsen did a complete 180, transforming his life and becoming one of the good guys. He joined Wired as a Senior Editor in 2005, successfully blowing the cover of sex offenders and helping law enforcement.

“CAPTAIN CRUNCH”

Long before guys like McKinnon, Joshi, Poulsen and LulzSec came along, Captain Crunch reigned supreme. Leading by example and inspiring a generation of hackers and pirates after him, John Draper – the phone phreak extraordinaire – is a legend among the original mischief mongers of the technology space.

Choosing to stay out of the limelight and leading a nomadic lifestyle, Draper



Send some over please

was a member of the Homebrew Computer Club – the crucible from which Silicon Valley culture and practices emerged. Draper’s legendary status in the history of technology is forever cemented due to his phone phreaking prowess and the invention of the (now) mythical “blue box” – a piece of hardware that played a critical role in the lives of Steve Wozniak and Steve Jobs, inspiring them to start Apple Computers.

“What’s the blue box,” you ask? It was an electronic frequency generator that when connected to an AT&T land-line phone’s receiver would help a caller make trunk calls and even international calls... for free. His nickname of Captain Crunch came from a toy whistle that was sold in Cap’n Crunch cereal boxes, whose 2600 Hz frequency matched with AT&T’s long line frequency to connect to a trunk call.

God knows how many blue boxes Draper sold, and helped others to make. But he was arrested for toll fraud in 1972 and sentenced to five years’ probation. Still a cool thing to do, though, don’t you think? 